

THE ROAD TO VINDANA

The King's Crusade — Module Five

OVERVIEW

The coalition, the Ward beside it now, marches the final stretch toward Vindana — and partway there, news catches up with them from the road they did not take. The second king, who led the other column, is dead: lost early, in water, his army come apart behind him. This module delivers that news and lets the party, and the coalition around them, sit with it before Vindana's siege begins in Module 6. It is shorter and quieter than the modules before it by design. Core scenes run two and a half to three hours; Optional Content fills out the rest of a five-hour session and can be cut cleanly if the table is short on time.

PLAYING THE NEWS

This module resolves Branch Ledger entry 1 — the road choice from Module One — regardless of which variant of Module Two the table played. If the party took the sea road (Module 2A), the second king took the mountain road and was lost fording a swollen river, much as the Ashgate crossing nearly cost the party something in that variant. If the party took the mountain road (Module 2B), the second king took the sea road and was lost in a storm, much as the party's own crossing was in Calanthe's telling. Either way, the parallel is deliberate: whatever the party's own road cost them, the other road cost more, and it is worth letting a player notice that without the module explaining it.

Scene	Target time	Notes
1. Word on the Road	15–20 min	A rider arrives first, before the full story does.
2. The Standing Water	60–90 min	The Four Voices, again — deliberately. The module's centerpiece.
3. Vindana in Sight	30–45 min	The march ends in view of the siege to come.
Optional Content	30–45 min	Run if the table has time; cut cleanly if not.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

The second king's death was exactly what it appears to be: an accident of weather and bad ground, not an ambush and not Vale's doing — he has never heard of this man and would not consider him worth the effort if he had. That plainness is the point. The coalition loses its second crown to a river or a storm, the same way real armies have, and the loss is not made more dramatic than it actually was. What the module is actually about is not the death itself but what the survivors do with it — and the old soldiers' belief that a king of that stamp does not die but sleeps in some hill, waiting until he is needed again, is offered here as one live option among several for how the coalition receives it, not the only one.

DM Only: the second king's realm is deliberately not named in this module. Oksitan is the plausible candidate by elimination — Auberitz is a grand duchy, Norvatch does not march — but that has never actually been settled, and neither this module nor any NPC in it should confirm it. If a player asks directly which realm lost its king, the honest answer any NPC can give is that word has not settled that far down the column yet, which is true and also convenient.

SCENE 1: WORD ON THE ROAD

The news arrives the way bad news on a march always does: badly, in pieces, ahead of anyone who actually knows the whole of it. A lone rider reaches the column first, half a day ahead of any official word.

Tam Ondry rides in on a horse that has clearly been ridden too hard for too long, and does not wait for permission before finding the nearest officer. "The other column," he says, and then has to stop and start again. "The king. He's not — he didn't make the crossing. Nobody's saying it plain yet, but I was there for the part before I wasn't, and I'm saying it plain. He's gone."

Tam is a Harrowmark rider, attached to the other column as a courier, and genuinely shaken rather than performing grief — let him answer the party's immediate questions plainly and incompletely, the way someone actually present for a disaster usually can. He does not have the full story; nobody does yet. That is what Scene 2 is for.

SCENE 2: THE STANDING WATER

By evening, the column has reached a Listening Water of its own — a broad, still pool fed by a spring, the kind of feature every Elduvish village seems to have one of within an hour's walk. Word has spread that this is where mourning is properly done in this land, and the coalition, uncertain of its own customs for a loss like this, borrows Elduvaine's without much discussion about whether it is entitled to.

Nobody organizes it. People simply arrive at the water's edge through the evening, in ones and twos, and say what they have to say to it. By full dark there have been enough voices that the water, when it finally answers, has a great deal to give back.

RUNNING THE SCENE

As in Module Three, read each voice below as its own boxed passage, with a pause between each. None of the four is lying. None of them is complete, and this time that incompleteness is doing real emotional work — the coalition genuinely does not agree yet on what happened or what it means, and the party is hearing that disagreement unfold in real time rather than as settled history.

A SOLDIER'S ACCOUNT

"...ford looked no worse than a dozen we'd already crossed. He went in ahead, the way he always did, wouldn't let anyone else take the lead line first. Current took the horse out from under him before anyone downstream could reach a rope to him. That's the whole of it. That's all it ever is, in the end — a bad step and cold water, no matter whose head wore the crown..."

AN OFFICER'S ACCOUNT

"...the column's command structure held, credit where it's due — his marshals had the sense to keep the line moving rather than let the army come apart on the riverbank grieving. But a coalition is a fragile thing to lose a crown out of, and I will not pretend to you that this doesn't change the arithmetic of everything that comes after it..."

WHAT THE SOLDIERS ARE ALREADY SAYING

"...my sergeant swears he's not dead, not really — swears a king like that doesn't just drown in a ditch, says he's sleeping somewhere under the water or under a hill same as the old stories tell it, and he'll wake up and come back for us when it matters most. I don't know if I believe it. I know I'd rather believe it than the alternative, and I'm not the only one..."

A PRIVATE GRIEF

"...I served his household eleven years and I don't even know what I'm meant to call this. Not treason, staying loyal to a dead man. Not foolishness either. I just wanted to say his name somewhere it would be heard, because nobody's asked me how I am, and I don't expect anybody will."

Let the table sit with this. If a player wants to speak at the water themselves, let it take their words and give them back once, faithfully, exactly as in Module Three. The scene's job is complete once all four voices have been heard; do not rush it to make room for Scene 3.

SCENE 3: VINDANA IN SIGHT

The column crests a final ridge the following day, subdued in a way it was not before Scene 2, and Vindana comes into view for the first time — walls, harbor, and the specific, particular dread of a siege that has not yet begun but is now unmistakably close.

The city sits where the coast folds around a natural harbor, walls pale even at this distance, and for a long moment nobody in the column says anything at all. Then, somewhere behind the party, someone starts walking again, and the rest of the column follows, because that is what a column does.

End the session here, on the sight of the city rather than on grief — the tone should turn forward, not linger. Hand off directly to Module 6 for the investment of Vindana.

PUZZLES AND SET PIECES

Who Is Speaking is the Standing Water, performed rather than summarised. Nine Weeks Into a Winter is the Held Winter under Optional Content, and it is a full ninety minutes with the wolves and the troll, or forty without them.

THE PUZZLE: WHO IS SPEAKING

The Standing Water gives back the same three months in four registers and none of them are lying. The puzzle is not what happened; the puzzle is working out which voice to believe about which part, and the module should never resolve it.

Play all four. Do not label them. The players work out who is who, and then work out that the disagreement is the information.

"And on the ninth day the King crossed at the ford in the sight of his whole army, and the water took him, and there was no enemy within forty miles, and God's judgement upon it is not for us to say."

"He went in first. That is all. He always went in first, he was seventy-one and he always went in first, and the water was not even deep, and I want somebody to write down that it was not deep."

"By order of the Marshal, the crossing is closed and the column will re-form on the near bank. Companies will draw three days' ration. There will be no further movement until the succession is settled."

"He is under it. Threnn keeps what the water takes and gives it back when there is need, and he is under it sleeping, and I will thank you not to say otherwise in front of the boy."

What each voice is reliable about: the court's account has the date and the place right and the judgement wrong. The soldier has the truth and no perspective. The proclamation has the consequences and no cause. The last one has nothing right at all and is the only one that tells the party what the coalition is going to be like for the next four modules.

DM Only: the fourth voice is the one that matters and it is not a puzzle to be solved. A broken column would very much rather believe its king is kept than drowned, and a party that goes around correcting people is arguing with grief rather than with a claim. Let them try. Let it go badly. This is also, quietly, the module where the campaign teaches that the Four Voices technique does not converge on a truth, which is the whole reason it is worth using.

SET PIECE: NINE WEEKS INTO A WINTER

Bryn Aeling was planted four days into spring seven hundred years ago and generations were married under it on that basis. It has been nine weeks into a winter it was never sown in for most of a year, and it is the most legible image of the draining in the campaign.

"You cross the hedge and the temperature drops eleven degrees in a single step and the sound goes. Behind you it is a warm afternoon in the Marches. In front of you there is forty acres of birch and apple standing in nine weeks of snow that has never once thawed, and every tree in it is in full blossom, and the blossom is frozen, and it has been frozen since it opened. Nothing has fallen. Nothing can fall. It is going to be like this until the trees die, and they are dying, slowly, and in the wrong order."

What is in it. Two winter wolves working the edges, who will shadow the party for an hour before committing. A troll

in the orchard-keeper's cottage, which is the reason the last two woodsmen did not come back. And the dryad, who is the actual content of the scene and is not an encounter.

Running the wolves and the troll together. Check it against your table before you commit. Two winter wolves is 1,400 XP and a troll is 1,800; at four monsters the multiplier is 2, which makes the adjusted total 6,400 and is a deadly encounter for five characters at 5th level and an extremely dangerous one for six. Either group alone is a full encounter and the module assumes they are met separately.

The dryad has been the spirit of a spring wood for three centuries and is now the spirit of a winter one, and she is neither hostile nor grateful nor able to leave. Use the Withering block in the bestiary if it comes to violence, and understand that a table which fights her has misread the scene. What she wants is for somebody to explain to her what has been done and why, and nobody in the party can, and that is the point.

DM Only: if the party asks whether killing Vale fixes her wood, the honest answer is that nobody knows and she does not expect it to. Do not have her forgive anyone. Do not have her curse anyone. She is a wood in the wrong season and the wrong season is not going to end because a war did.

NPC PROFILES

TAM ONDRY

A young Harrowmark rider, courier-attached to the other column, badly shaken by what he witnessed and not yet good at hiding it. Speech: plain, halting when the subject is the crossing itself, otherwise ordinary and even easygoing — grief has not replaced his personality, just interrupted it.

Open thread: Tam is a natural recurring minor NPC for the rest of the campaign — a DM can use him as a courier again whenever a module needs news to arrive from elsewhere, now already established as reliable and already known to the party.

OPTIONAL CONTENT

WHAT THE COALITION BELIEVES NOW

If the table wants more of the coalition's reaction before Vindana, let the party spend time in camp hearing how differently Oksitan, Auberitz, and Harrowmark soldiers are each processing the loss — without confirming which realm the crown belonged to (see the DM-Only note above). Play this for texture: an argument about what kind of memorial, if any, is appropriate; a quiet, un-discussed uptick in soldiers touching still water on the march since. No mechanical stakes.

THE HELD WINTER

The road to Vindana runs within half a day of a birch wood that was planted four days into spring three hundred years ago and has been nine weeks into a winter it was never sown in for most of a year. A party that goes to look finds the most legible single image of the draining the campaign has: a wood in the wrong season, dying of it, with an ecology that has moved in behind the change.

What lives there now came down out of the hills after the cold did. A pair of winter wolves (SRD, CR 3, 700 XP each) hunt the wood's edges and will shadow a small party for an hour before committing. Deeper in, a troll (SRD, CR 5, 1,800 XP) has taken the old orchard-keeper's cottage and is the reason the last two woodsmen did not come back — a straightforward, dangerous fight for a party of this level, and one that rewards anybody who remembers what regeneration does and does not survive. A DM running the wolves and the troll together should check the total against their table before committing; either alone is a full encounter.

The wood also has a dryad (SRD, CR 1), and she is the actual content of the scene. She is not an encounter. She has been the spirit of a spring wood for three centuries and is now the spirit of a winter one, and she is neither hostile nor grateful nor able to leave. She will talk, at length, and what she wants is for somebody to explain to her what has been done and why, which nobody in the party can do. A table that fights her has misread the scene; a table that sits down with her gets the campaign's grief in one conversation, from something that is not a person and is nonetheless quite plainly grieving.

DM Only: if the party asks whether killing Vale fixes her wood, the honest answer is that nobody knows and she does not expect it to. Do not have her forgive anyone, and do not have her curse anyone. She is a wood in the wrong season, and the wrong season is not going to end because a war did.

A SKIRMISH ON THE RIDGE

If the table wants combat before this module ends, a small occupation patrol — scouting Vindana's approaches, not expecting a coalition column this size — can be spotted and engaged on the final ridge before Scene 3. Use the Occupation Guard stat block from Module 3 (three or four is sufficient); they flee to warn the city the moment the fight turns against them, which is itself useful information for Module 6 rather than a failure state.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

- **Branch Ledger entry 1, resolved.** Record here how the party's own road compared to the second king's — what their crossing cost against what his cost him. This closes the loop opened in Module One.
- **How the party engaged with the mourning at the Standing Water.** Whether they spoke at the water themselves, listened only, or kept apart from it entirely — worth a line in the ledger, since it is the party's first real exposure to how this coalition grieves, and it will not be its last.

LOOT

- **A flask of Listening Water.** Drawn at the Standing Water while the mourning was going on, by whoever thought to. It holds what was said at its mouth and gives it back once, in the speaker's own voice, and then it is only water. Whatever the party chose to put in it is the point; a DM should ask, and should write down the answer.

- **Otherwise, nothing material.** This module is not about treasure any more than Module Three was. Its currency is information and tone — the Branch Ledger entry above is the actual payoff.

THE REFRAIN

*By thought, and by word, and by deed,
the king's own chosen kept their creed.
Far from home, where the quiet land lay,
they held the line, and would not stray.*